MERCHANT SERVICES · PRODUCT

VERSION 2

Product Delivery Operating Model

Three work types, one lifecycle, and an AI layer that prepares the evidence for every decision, across UPOP, Credential Vault, Authentication Optimization and Payment Instrument Intelligence.

> AI prepares, analyzes, detects, recommends and learns. Product leaders stay accountable for decisions, trade-offs and outcomes.

WORK TYPE 01

Strategic Initiatives

New capabilities that move platform strategy

WORK TYPE 02

Payment Brand Initiatives

Network mandates and their upstream product impact

WORK TYPE 03

Platform Enhancements

Run the product, submitted through SIF

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Three work types, one operating model

v2 changes the operating model from a way of moving work into a way of making product decisions. **Strategic Initiatives (SI)**, **Payment Brand Initiatives (PBI)** and **Platform Enhancements (PE)** all feed one lifecycle. An AI layer prepares the analysis at every stage. A new outcome gate feeds results back into prioritization.

Governing principle. AI prepares, analyzes, detects, recommends and learns. Product leaders stay accountable for decisions, trade-offs and outcomes. AI alone never passes an item through a gate.

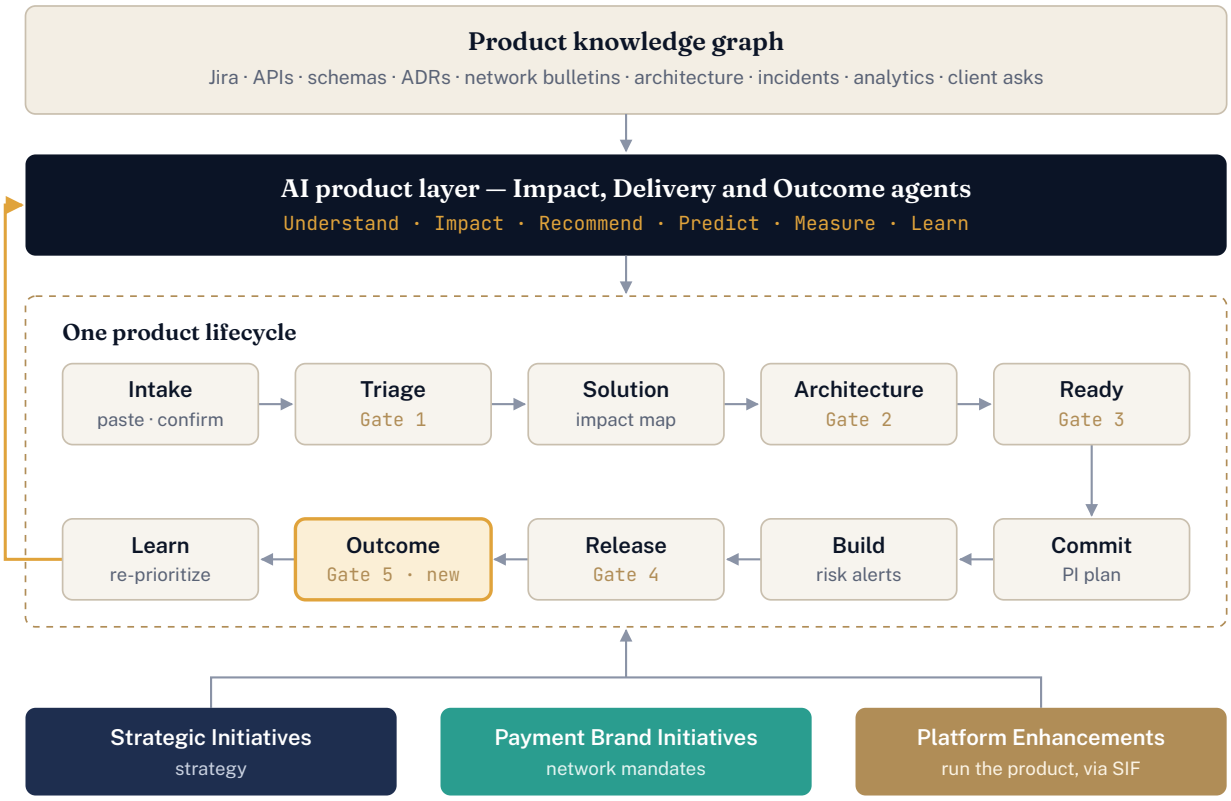
Work type	What triggers it	What sets urgency	What sets value
SI **Strategic**	Platform strategy and the roadmap	The target window leadership sets	Product leadership
PBI **Payment Brand**	Network mandates that reach front-end products, not the payment rails	The network effective date, which is fixed	Product leadership decides value-add beyond the mandated minimum
PE **Platform Enh.**	Day-2 fallout, PBI carryover, client asks, non-mandated network items	Class of service	Product leadership, within a protected capacity floor

SI, PBI and PE differ in where work comes from and how urgent it is. They do not need different methods. All four products run through the same system: UPOP (the payment processing front end), Credential Vault, Authentication Optimization and Payment Instrument Intelligence.

Constraints the model is built around

- The same Solution Architects, Design Authority and tech leads serve all three work types. Design time is the scarcest resource.
- The networks fix PBI deadlines, and those deadlines get first claim on capacity.
- PE has no natural sponsor. Without protected capacity, it loses to SI and PBI every PI.
- Cross-product impact is the hardest call and the one most often missed.
- AI output is only as good as the data behind it. Here that includes regulated payment data, so data access, classification and model-risk review must be settled before any agent goes live.

AI prepares every stage; people decide at five gates



All work enters one intake. Gate 5 outcome data flows back, so each later decision improves.

What changed from v1

v1	v2
Three streams	Three work types, one Product Delivery Operating Model
Requester fills in intake fields	Requester pastes the source, AI structures it, and the PM confirms
Cross-product impact map built by hand	AI drafts the impact map with evidence; the PM accepts or overrides it
PM writes the solution brief	AI drafts it; the PM challenges and approves it
DA reviews each design from scratch	AI pre-reviews; the DA resolves the open decisions
Readiness checked by hand	Automated Definition of Ready report
Slippage found after it happens	Delivery risk predicted in advance
Four gates, ending at release	Five gates; Gate 5 checks whether the outcome happened
Fixed 60/40 SI/PE split	Split recommended from evidence each PI; leadership decides
Client asks handled one at a time	Similar asks detected and scored as platform opportunities
Knowledge held by people	Product knowledge graph and an automatically maintained decision log

Ten stages, five gates

Every item goes through the same ten stages and five gates. At each stage, AI prepares the evidence and a named person makes the call.

	Stage	AI prepares	Human decides	Gate
01	**Intake**	Parses the pasted mandate, request or problem; fills in work type, source, dates, products and a client-facing flag; lists missing information	Requester confirms the extract	—
02	**Triage**	Suggests an owner and size; flags duplicates and related work	Leadership accepts, declines, merges or re-routes; names the lead PM	GATE 1
03	**Product solution**	First-pass impact map with evidence for each product; draft solution brief	Lead PM accepts or overrides each impact call; approves the brief	—
04	**Architecture**	Pre-review against ADRs, NFRs, API contracts and incident history; lists conflicts and open questions	Sol Arch designs; the DA decides	GATE 2
05	**Ready**	Definition of Ready report, with blockers	PO and tech lead confirm readiness in PBR	GATE 3
06	**Commit**	Capacity recommendation by work type, with evidence	Leadership sets the allocation at PI planning	—
07	**Build**	Delivery confidence; scope-change and dependency alerts; decision log from design forums	Tech leads deliver; product answers questions and approves trade-offs	—
08	**Release**	Draft release notes; certification evidence checklist	Product accepts against the criteria	GATE 4
09	**Outcome**	KPI movement, client adoption and unexpected behavior at 30, 60 and 90 days	Product and business owners judge whether the hypothesis held	GATE 5
10	**Learn**	Updates impact patterns, estimates and platformization signals from what actually happened	Leadership re-prioritizes: expand, modify or retire	—

Intake: paste, structure, confirm

Requesters no longer fill in nine fields. They paste the source: a network bulletin, a client email or a problem statement. AI returns a structured draft and a list of what's missing. The requester confirms it, and triage gets a complete ticket. Every item still enters Jira. No ticket, no work.

Close-out rule is unchanged

Every gap or Day-2 item becomes a linked PE ticket with a parent, a reason and an owner. Deferred work is never lost.

Roles

Activity	Product (you, PMs)	POs	Sol Arch	Design Authority	Tech leads	PMO	PBI team	Leadership
Intake and triage	**A**	C	I	—	I	I	C (PBI)	I
Impact and solution	**A**	R	C	—	C	—	C (PBI)	—
Architecture design	C	C	R	**A**	C	—	—	—
Refinement (PBR)	**A**	R	C	—	R	—	—	—
Delivery tracking	C	C	—	—	R	**A**	C (PBI)	I
Outcome review (Gate 5)	**A**	R	—	—	C	I	—	C
Priority and allocation	R	—	—	—	C	—	Sets PBI dates	**A**
AI agents and their data	**A** for use	R for feedback	C	C	C	—	—	I

R = Responsible · A = Accountable · C = Consulted · I = Informed. No AI agent is Accountable or Responsible for any decision.

Definition of Ready GATE 3

Checked automatically, confirmed by people

- Problem, outcome and acceptance criteria are written
- The cross-product impact map is complete; every "no impact" call has its evidence and the name of the person who accepted it
- The DA decision is recorded; open design questions have an owner and a date
- Non-functional needs are stated: latency, availability, PCI scope, network certification
- Day-1 scope and Day-2 candidates are split explicitly
- The success hypothesis and the KPI Gate 5 will measure are written down
- The work is sized, and each dependency is named and confirmed by the team that owns it

The report marks each line as met, at risk or missing, and names the blockers. An item that is not ready can still be committed, but only by a named person who records why.

Definition of Done GATE 4

- Product has signed off that the acceptance criteria are met
- Certification or compliance evidence is stored, where required
- Client-facing documentation and release notes are updated
- The KPI baseline is captured and the Gate 5 review dates are booked
- Every descoped item exists as a linked PE ticket

Urgency is not value

Every item is scored on two separate axes. **Urgency** asks when the work must happen. **Value** asks why we should invest more than the minimum. PBI sets urgency. Product leadership decides how much value-add scope each item earns.



Most PBI items sit in the right half. Whether a mandate is Mandatory or Transformational is a product decision, not the network's.

Capacity allocation each PI

1. Mandated PBI minimums take first claim, sized back from each compliance date.
2. AI recommends how to split the remaining capacity between SI and PE. It weighs demand, strategic value, revenue and client impact, regulatory urgency, operational risk, engineering capacity, historical delivery rate and cost of delay. Leadership decides and records why.
3. The starting split is about **60% SI / 40% PE** until there are two PIs of history. After that, it is a default to challenge every PI, not a fixed rule.
4. Within each work type, rank by WSJF: value, time criticality and risk reduction, divided by size.
5. An expedite lane, capped at a small share of capacity, covers production-affecting client escalations between PIs.

PBI value-add is a separate decision

Each PBI is split in two. The mandated minimum ships by the deadline. Value-add is ranked as PE, on its value. A mandate that is urgent but low-value gets the minimum and nothing more.

Strategic Initiatives

In SI, product decides how a new capability fits across all four products before engineering designs it. AI does the drafting, so the PM spends time challenging the drafts and making trade-offs.

	Step	Owner	AI prepares	What the human does	Exit
01	**Intake**	Sponsor, via lead PM	Structured intake from the pasted initiative statement; list of missing information	Confirms the outcome, sponsor and target window	Minimum fields confirmed
02	**Triage**	Product leadership (weekly)	Related and duplicate work; suggested size and owner	Accept, decline, merge or re-route to PE; name a lead PM	GATE 1
03	**Product solution**	Lead PM with POs	Draft brief: problem, outcome, affected products, API and data changes, dependencies, Day-1 vs Day-2, risks and success metrics; impact map with evidence	Challenges the draft; accepts or overrides every impact call; sets the success hypothesis	Brief approved in design forum
04	**Architecture**	Sol Arch; DA decides	Pre-review of latency, PCI scope, availability, backward compatibility, API versioning, data residency and failure modes; conflicts with existing ADRs; questions for the DA	Sol Arch designs; DA resolves the listed decisions	GATE 2
05	**Refinement**	POs and tech leads (monthly PBR)	Draft epics, features and acceptance criteria; readiness report	Size, correct and confirm the drafts	GATE 3
06	**Plan and track**	PMO	Dependency map; delivery confidence	Commit at PI planning; manage the RAID log in Scrum of Scrums	Committed
07	**Build**	Tech leads, product in the loop	Scope-change and dependency alerts; ADRs drafted from design forums	Answer product questions within two business days; approve trade-offs	Features complete
08	**Gaps and Day-2**	Lead PM	Candidate Day-2 items drawn from scope changes	Absorb, trade out, or move to a linked PE ticket	Every gap has a disposition
09	**Release**	Lead PM	Release notes; KPI baseline	Accept against the criteria	GATE 4
10	**Outcome**	Lead PM with business owner	KPI and adoption analysis at 30, 60 and 90 days	Judge the hypothesis; expand, modify or retire	GATE 5

Rules specific to SI

- Any scope change after Gate 2 needs a logged trade-off: what moves out, or which date moves.
- An SI with no success hypothesis and no Gate 5 KPI does not pass Gate 3.

Payment Brand Initiatives

In PBI the network sets the date. The product team adds value through fast, accurate impact analysis. The PBI team owns the mandate and the rails. Product owns what the mandate changes upstream in the four front-end products. A **Network Mandate Copilot** analyzes every bulletin as soon as it is announced.

Network Mandate Copilot: what it produces for each bulletin

1. Effective dates and compliance deadlines
2. Mandatory changes separated from optional ones (optional ones become PE candidates)
3. Affected message elements and message versions
4. Certification requirements and how long they take
5. APIs that expose the affected fields
6. Affected products, with evidence and a confidence level
7. A comparison with the current implementation, showing the gaps
8. Clients likely to be affected, and whether merchants need to be told
9. Draft Jira epics, features and test scenarios
10. A compliance timeline working back from the effective date

	Step	Owner	AI prepares	What the human does	Exit
01	**Mandate intake**	PBI team	The Copilot ingests the bulletin when it is announced	Confirm the extract and the rail-side scope	Intake confirmed
02	**Impact screen**	Lead PM (fixed SLA)	Impact matrix for each product (none, low or high), with evidence and confidence	Accept or override every row; write the reason for each override and each "no impact" call	Matrix signed off
03	**Route**	Product leadership	Recommended route	No impact: close with evidence. Rails only: the PBI team owns it. Front-end impact: continue	GATE 1
04	**Product solution**	Lead PM with POs	Draft brief, split into the mandated minimum and value-add candidates	Approve the minimum; send the value-add to PE ranking	Brief approved
05	**Architecture**	Sol Arch; DA decides	Pre-review, including the interfaces with the rail teams	Sol Arch designs; DA decides	GATE 2
06	**Refinement**	POs and tech leads	Work sized back from the compliance date, including certification	Confirm	GATE 3
07	**Coordinate**	PMO	Mandate calendar; alerts for deadlines at risk	Coordinate the PBI, rail and product teams	Committed
08	**Build**	Tech leads, product in the loop	Delivery confidence against the deadline	Escalate any threat to the deadline in the same week	Features complete
09	**Certify and close**	Lead PM with PBI team	Certification evidence checklist; list of carryover work	Certify and store the evidence; carryover becomes linked PE tickets	GATE 4

Impact questions: the Copilot answers first, the PM validates

The question for every product: *does this mandate change what we send, store, decide or expose?*

Product	Questions
UPOP	New or changed merchant API fields? New data elements to carry into authorization? Changed response codes or retry rules? A merchant-facing change that needs notice?
Credential Vault	Changes to token provisioning, lifecycle or cryptograms? Rules for card-on-file or stored-credential indicators? A change to data retention or PCI scope?
Authentication Optimization	3DS version or message changes? New exemption or indicator rules? Changes to liability shift or challenge flows?
Payment Instrument Intelligence	New or changed BIN ranges, product IDs or attributes? Are downstream consumers of those attributes affected?

Rules specific to PBI

- The Copilot runs when a mandate is announced, not when rail work starts. The PBI team routes each bulletin to it at announcement.
- The deadline is fixed; scope and approach can flex. Anything beyond the mandated minimum is ranked as PE, on its value.
- AI makes "no impact" calls easier to check, but they still have to be checked. Each one keeps its evidence and the name of the person who accepted it.

07 · WORK TYPE 3

Platform Enhancements: run the product

PE is a continuous flow. Items can be captured at any time. They are submitted through **SIF** so tech capacity can be allocated, made ready each month, and pulled into each PI within a protected capacity floor. v2 gives PE a new job: spotting when several client asks are really one platform capability.

Sources of PE work

Source	Arrives from	Required on the ticket
SI Day-2 and gaps	SI close-out or decisions made during build	Parent SI link, reason for deferral, owner
PBI carryover and value-add	Partially implemented mandates; optional network changes	Parent PBI link; whether any part is still mandated
Client asks	Clients, sales, relationship managers	Client, commercial value, custom or platform
Non-mandated network items	Optional network programs	Network reference, benefit to merchants
Team-identified	POs, tech leads, incidents, competitive gaps	Evidence and the product affected
Gate 5 follow-ups	Outcome reviews that call for a change	Parent initiative, the KPI gap

Flow

	Stage	Cadence	What happens
01	**Capture**	Continuous	The requester pastes the ask. AI structures it and checks for similar existing items.

	Stage	Cadence	What happens
02	**Groom**	Weekly	A backlog review with Pratik, Vishal and the POs, working from an AI pre-read that covers new items, duplicates, clusters and aging items.
03	**Submit through SIF**	Monthly	Groomed items go through SIF, the PE intake process, so tech capacity is allocated before that month's PBR.
04	**Refine**	Monthly PBR	Items are brought up to the automated Definition of Ready.
05	**Commit**	Quarterly PI	Ranked PE work is pulled into the PE capacity floor.
06	**Track**	Monthly	Items are reviewed against delivery confidence. An item that is slipping goes back through ranking.

Classes of service

Class	What it is	Handling
Expedite	A production-affecting client escalation	Capped expedite lane, between PIs
Fixed-date	Work tied to a client or network date	Sized back from the date
Standard	A normal enhancement	WSJF ranking
Hygiene	Debt and upkeep	Its own share of the PE floor
Strategic leverage NEW	Looks like PE, but would remove work that repeats across clients or products	Evaluated as a platform capability; may be promoted to SI

Platformization score

AI groups similar client asks and scores each group's platform potential. The score draws on how many clients are asking, the TPV and revenue they represent, how similar the requirements are, strategic relevance, reuse potential, and the cost of running a bespoke build. A high-scoring group goes to triage as a candidate platform capability instead of five custom builds. The PM confirms the group is real before any tickets are merged.

Rules specific to PE

- A client ask built for one client only needs leadership sign-off. By default, generalize it or decline it.
- An item untouched for two PIs is re-ranked, merged or closed with a reason. The original sponsor is told when a Day-2 item is closed.
- Every month, leadership sees Day-2 and PE backlog size, age and platformization clusters by product.

08 · GATE 5

Outcome review

v1 stopped at "did we deliver?" v2 adds a second question: did the change produce the outcome we expected? The hypothesis and KPI are set at Gate 3. The baseline is captured at Gate 4. The review comes once the release has had time to take effect.

When	What happens	Who
GATE 3	The success hypothesis and the Gate 5 KPI are written into the item	Lead PM
GATE 4	The KPI baseline is captured and review dates are booked	Lead PM, analytics
DAY 30	AI outcome analysis: early KPI movement, adoption and unexpected behavior	Outcome agent; PM reviews
DAY 60	Product and business review of the trend	Lead PM, business owner
DAY 90	Gate 5 decision	Product leadership

Questions Gate 5 answers

- Did the KPI move, and by how much? Examples: authorization rate, token coverage, frictionless authentication rate
- Did client behavior and adoption change?
- Did revenue or cost change?
- Did operational burden or incidents increase?
- Did the original hypothesis hold?

Gate 5 decisions

Expand · **Keep** · **Modify** (as a linked PE item) · **Retire**

Each decision and its evidence feeds the Learn stage, which improves later estimates and impact calls. Every Gate 5 analysis names the comparison it used: a control group, a seasonality-adjusted before-and-after, or holdout merchants.

09 · PEOPLE

How the PM role changes

The PM's work shifts from producing documents to making judgments.

Today	With the Product Delivery Operating Model
Gather requirements	Define the problem and the hypothesis
Write briefs and impact maps	Challenge and approve AI drafts
Chase status and dependencies	Act on exceptions the Delivery Agent raises
Maintain Jira hygiene	Make cross-product trade-offs
Report on delivery	Own outcomes at Gate 5

AI takes on most of: document analysis, first-pass impact analysis, requirements drafting, Jira hygiene, status synthesis, dependency tracking, architecture pre-review, meeting preparation, decision logging and outcome analysis.

PMs spend more time on: strategy, customer understanding, prioritization, economics, experimentation, cross-product decisions and platformization.

This affects hiring and coaching. PMs will be judged on the quality of their overrides and their outcomes, not on how many documents they produce. Plan the skills shift deliberately.

Three agents, embedded in the workflow

Start with three agents, not twenty use cases. Each one targets a specific weakness in today's model. Each one works inside tools people already use, so nobody has to learn another app.

Agent	Inputs	Produces	Weakness it targets	Phase
Product Impact Agent incl. Network Mandate Copilot	Mandates, client asks, initiatives; APIs, schemas, ADRs, BIN data	Structured intake; product, API, data, architecture, client and regulatory impact; dependencies; evidence and confidence	Missed cross-product impact; weak "no impact" calls	**1**
Product Delivery Agent	Jira, dependencies, decisions, test and certification status, delivery history	Readiness report; delivery confidence; blockers; scope creep; Day-2 candidates; escalations; meeting pre-reads; decision log drafts	Execution overhead; slippage found too late	**2**
Product Outcome Agent	Release data, transaction analytics, client adoption, cost	KPI movement; adoption; revenue and cost impact; unexpected behavior; recommended follow-up	No learning after release	**3**

Embedded, not another app

Where	Action	Returns
Jira intake	`Analyze`	Structured ticket, missing fields, similar items
Network bulletin	`Impact`	Copilot output and draft epics
Solution brief	`Draft`	An 80% draft for the PM to challenge
Architecture page	`Review`	Concerns, ADR conflicts, questions for the DA
PBR backlog	`Ready?`	Definition of Ready report
PI backlog	`Allocate`	Capacity recommendation with evidence
Initiative	`Risk`	Delivery confidence and what is driving it
Release	`Measure`	Gate 5 analysis at 30, 60 and 90 days
Leadership dashboard	`Explain`	What changed and what needs a decision

Decision log, maintained automatically

In design forums, AI drafts each ADR as a decision is made. The draft covers the decision, reason, rejected alternatives, owner, date, affected products and revisit trigger. The decision owner confirms it. It is then linked to Jira, APIs, initiatives and later mandates, which gives the organization a memory it can query.

Product knowledge graph

The agents are only as good as what they can see. The graph makes these relationships explicit:

- Network rule → requirement → API, product and data element
- Product → capability → architecture component → service
- Service → clients → transaction behavior
- All of the above → the initiatives and ADRs that changed them

It can then answer questions like *"What breaks if this rule changes?"* or *"Which products consume this BIN attribute?"* Build it in stages. Start with Jira, API specs, ADRs and bulletins.

Meeting cadence

The same forums continue, but each now starts from an AI pre-read, and meetings are only for decisions and exceptions. The monthly calendar adds an outcome review for Gate 5.

AI pre-read, 24 hours before each forum: what changed · what needs a decision · what is at risk · what is blocked · what needs escalation · what can be handled asynchronously. If the pre-read shows nothing to decide, that week's forum is cancelled.

Weekly, in order from Monday to Friday

Day	Forum	Purpose	Attendees	Output
MON	**Product design and triage** 60 min	Make Gate 1 calls; challenge the AI-drafted briefs and impact maps	Product team	Gate 1 decisions; briefs ready for DA
TUE	**Design review** 60 min	Resolve the open decisions from the AI pre-review	DA, tech leads, POs, product	Gate 2 decisions; ADRs confirmed
WED	**Backlog review** 45 min	Clear readiness blockers; confirm platformization clusters; improve PBR	Pratik, Vishal, POs, product	SIF submissions; groomed backlog
THU	**Delivery review** 30 min	Exceptions only: items whose delivery confidence has dropped	Tech leads, PMO, product	Escalations for Friday
FRI	**Leadership update** 30 min	Achievements, then Now / Next / Later; decisions needed	Leadership, product	Priority calls

Monthly and quarterly

Cadence	Forum	Purpose	Output
MONTHLY	**Product Backlog Refinement**	Bring SI and PE items to Definition of Ready	Ready items for the next PI
MONTHLY	**PBI mandate review**	Mandate calendar, Copilot impact matrices, deadlines at risk	Updated impact matrix and calendar
MONTHLY	**Outcome review** NEW	Gate 5 decisions for releases at 90 days; trends at 30 and 60 days	Expand, keep, modify or retire
MONTHLY	**Leadership scorecard** (replaces one Friday)	Flow, outcomes and AI performance	Capacity and priority adjustments
QUARTERLY	**PI planning and review**	Set the allocation from the AI recommendation; commit the PI; review the last one	Committed PI plan

A forum that makes no decisions for three weeks is merged into another.

Process first, then three agents

Rollout happens in four phases. A phase starts only when the one before it meets its exit criterion. Targets for each measure are set after two PIs of baseline data.

Phased rollout

Phase	Timing	Scope	Exit criterion
0 · Process	DAYS 1–90	v1 lifecycle, single intake, SIF cut-off, Definitions of Ready and Done, the Day-2 rule, the new cadence, Gate 5 fields added to items	Next PI committed by work type; every Day-2 item is a linked PE ticket
1 · Impact	NEXT PI	Product Impact Agent and Network Mandate Copilot, piloted on PBI; paste-and-confirm intake	Copilot runs on every new mandate; override and missed-impact rates are measured
2 · Delivery	FOLLOWING PI	Readiness report, delivery confidence, meeting pre-reads, decision log drafts	Forums run on pre-reads; the readiness report is used at PBR
3 · Outcome	NEXT TWO PIs	Outcome Agent, Gate 5 reviews, AI capacity recommendation, platformization score	First Gate 5 decisions made; allocation set from evidence

Leadership scorecard

- **Flow:** days from intake to Gate 1 and from Gate 1 to Ready, by work type; share of items that were Ready at planning; committed vs delivered
- **Risk:** PBI mandates at risk against their dates; Day-2 and PE backlog size and age, by product
- **Outcomes:** Gate 5 results; one KPI per product, such as authorization rate, token coverage or frictionless authentication rate
- **AI performance:** PM override rate per agent; missed-impact rate; calibration of confidence levels; time saved per brief and per impact screen
- **Platformization:** client-ask clusters promoted to platform capabilities

Open decisions

- [ ] Monthly SIF cut-off date
- [ ] Starting SI/PE split, and when the evidence-based recommendation replaces it
- [ ] Impact-screen SLA for PBI mandates, agreed with the PBI team
- [ ] Who chairs triage, and whether a platform product lead rotates
- [ ] Jira structure: one project with tags, or separate projects
- [ ] Whether PBI covers all networks or only the card brands in scope
- [ ] Which data sources Phase 1 agents may read, and the model-risk approval path
- [ ] Whether to build or buy the agents and graph, and which team owns them
- [ ] The Gate 5 KPI for each product, and who owns attribution analysis